

Chapter 1: The Ruin of Us



"I told you not to mess it up."

The elder twin's voice cut through the stale air like a blade. He stood over the wreckage—torn parchments, shattered glass, and the smudged remains of something ancient, something forbidden.

The younger twin flinched. *"I-I didn't mean to! I thought...."*

"No. You didn't think." His brother's eyes, cold as the stone walls around them, flicked toward the heavy wooden door. Dust rained from the ceiling with each pounding strike against it.

BOOM.

The door shuddered. The iron hinges groaned.

Outside, something was waiting. Something *hungry*.

"Do you have any idea what you've done?" the elder twin hissed, grabbing his brother's collar. *"It knows we're here now."*

BOOM. BOOM.

A crack splintered across the door. The candlelight flickered, shadows stretching like clawed fingers across the ruined chamber.

The younger twin swallowed hard. *"What... what do we do?"*

His brother's grip tightened. *"We run."*

"Run where? The younger twin asked!

There's only this deep well inside here, and we don't know what's inside it. It will be suicide...

"And staying here, waiting for that monster, is suicide too." Elder twin replied!

The elder twin's jaw clenched. He turned to the well in the center of the chamber a gaping maw of darkness, its depths unknown. Dust curled at its edges, disturbed by the shaking ground. The stone walls trembled as another deafening **BOOM** cracked through the room.

"Then choose your death," he said, voice cold. *"A monster we can see, or a darkness we can't?"*

The younger twin's breath hitched. His heart slammed against his ribs, torn between terror and instinct. Another blow from outside—the door splintered, a clawed hand pushing through the gap, its black talons curling against the wood.

A guttural snarl seeped through the cracks.

"We don't have time." The elder twin grabbed his brother's wrist, dragging him toward the well. He peered inside. Endless dark. No wind. No sound.

The creature outside roared—a sound that didn't belong in this world.

The younger twin hesitated. *"What if it's worse down there?"*

The elder twin's lips curled into something between a smirk and a grimace. *"Then at least we'll die knowing."*

The younger twin's scream was lost in the chaos as the door burst open

Echoes that Never Lived

The twins braced for a monster—claws, fangs, death.

But there was *nothing*.

The corridor outside stretched empty, its silence louder than any roar. Dust swirled in the dim torchlight. No beast. No shadows moving. Just... void.

Then—

"Wake up, honey. Time to eat"

The voice echoed, soft but **wrong**. It didn't belong to this place. It didn't belong to *them*. *Like the voice was calling the monster to eat. Calling the sleeping monster to wake up. To wake up and eat the feared twins.*

The elder twin whipped around, his pulse a hammer in his skull. His brother stood frozen, face pale, eyes wide with something deeper than fear.

"Did you hear that?" the younger twin whispered.

A long silence. Then—

"Who said that?"

The elder twin stepped forward, gripping his brother's shoulder. His fingers dug in. *"This isn't real."*

The younger twin trembled. His form flickered, like a candle's dying flame.

"You're not real."

The words struck the air like a curse. The younger twin's body convulsed—then his skin cracked like glass, black smoke curling from within. He staggered, reaching out—his fingers dissolved into mist before they could touch.

"No—no, wait, I—"

The last of him unraveled into darkness. The smoke twisted, coiled—then vanished, as if he had never been there at all.

The elder twin stood alone.

Heart pounding. Breath shallow.

The well yawned before him, its depths unreadable.

And from its darkness, a voice whispered—

"Wake up, honey."

The elder twin's breath came in ragged gasps. The air was *too still*. His younger brother was gone—nothing remained, not even the black smoke that had swallowed him.

"No... no, that's not right."

His voice trembled.

His fingers curled into his own arms, pressing, pinching—*feeling*. He was here. He was real. *Wasn't he?*

But the stone floor beneath him felt colder. The air felt thinner. Like something was... fading.

"I should be the one disappearing," he whispered.

His thoughts cracked, spiraling.

A memory surfaced—*had there ever been a younger twin?* Or had he been talking to himself all along?

His knees buckled.

Then—



Chapter 2: The awakening

Between the Pages.

A soft scratching sound filled the air. Not the echoes of a castle, but the glide of a pen across paper.

A study desk. A dimly lit room.

A young woman sat hunched over an open notebook, her fingers curled around a pen. Her long hair spilled over her shoulder as she wrote, her brows furrowed in deep concentration. The window to her left was slightly open, the cool night air stirring the papers on her desk.

She paused.

Something felt... off.

Her gaze flicked to the last sentence she had written.

"I should be the one disappearing."

"What could that possibly mean" She thought!

A shiver crawled down her spine.

She turned her head slightly—just enough to glance at the darkened window.

And in its reflection...She could clearly see herself writing. But what scared the soul out of her that, that reflection wasn't still and similar as she was looking in the mirror. The shadow was moving, it was writing with her head down.

Her fingers trembled slightly as she looked back at them and started writing again.

BOOM. She flinched. Her breath hitched, and for a second, she forgot where she was.

She stared at the words she had just written:

"The door shuddered. The iron hinges groaned."

Her chest rose and fell. Slowly. And too slowly, outside, the wind howled.

Then—

BOOM.

This time, it wasn't coming from her page.

It came from the window.

Her pulse spiked. She turned, barely breathing. The glass pane rattled, as if something had just struck it—hard.

For a moment, she sat frozen.

Then, slowly, her gaze fell back to her notebook.

The words stared back at her.

"BOOM. The door shuddered."

The thought clawed at her mind, creeping in like a whisper in the dark.

Outside, the wind slammed against the window again.

She exhaled, shaking her head. *It's just the storm.* Just the wind. Just...

She turned her head slightly—just enough to glance at the darkened window.

The pounding was gone.

The wind outside had settled. The night stretched quiet, save for the faint ticking of her desk clock.

She let out a slow breath. *It was just the storm.*

Closing the notebook, she leaned back in her chair, pressing her fingers against her temples. Writing always did this to her—dragged her too deep into her own mind, tangled thoughts with reality until everything felt... strange.

She glanced at the time. **11:47 PM.**

Late. But sleep wasn't calling her yet. It rarely did.

She sighed and stood, stretching her arms above her head. The wooden floor creaked under her bare feet as she made her way to the window. She pulled it open slightly, letting the crisp night air brush against her skin.

Being alone had its peace. But sometimes, *too much silence felt heavy.*

She tapped her fingers against the windowpane, staring at the empty street below. No voices, no passing cars. Just stillness.

Then, as if out of habit, her mind wandered.

What if someone was watching?

She shook the thought away with a quiet chuckle. *God, I need sleep.*

Pushing off the window, she walked toward the bed, switching off the desk lamp as she passed.

Darkness settled in.

And as she lay down, staring at the ceiling, a small thought whispered at the back of her mind—

"Did I really close my notebook?"

Her hands felt cold. She rubbed them together, trying to shake off the strange feeling creeping over her.

Maybe I'm just tired.

But suddenly, the whole room *tilted.*

The floor beneath her felt like it was being pulled away.

Her body collapsed into darkness.

Peace Is Just a Pause

And then—she opened her eyes.

Sunlight streamed through the window. Birds chirped outside.

A 19 years old young lady. Name's **Ally**.

She was sleeping on her desk with her head in her notebook. Her room looked the same, but the eerie night was gone. "*A dream...?*" she whispered to herself. The window was open, letting in a cold afternoon breeze.

She exhaled, pressing her palm against her forehead.

"That felt so real."

For a moment, she just lay there, trying to piece it all together.

Then, a small, uneasy thought crept in.

But... in the dream, I thought I was already awake.

Her fingers twitched. A soft breeze brushed against her skin.

She blinked.

The world around her was still. No pounding. No eerie silence. Just... the faint rustling of leaves outside.

Her head was resting on her notebook. The desk lamp was still on, casting a dim glow over the wooden surface.

She lifted her head slowly, groggy and a little cold. The window was open. The cool air mixed with a strange warmth, brushing against her face. Her notebook lay beneath her arms.

The pages were blank.

Her breath caught in her throat.

But... I wrote something. Didn't I?

She ran her fingers over the paper, half-expecting to feel the indent of words she had written. But there was nothing. No sign of her frantic scribbling.

A shiver ran down her spine—not from the cold, but from something deeper. Had it all been a dream?

She turned toward the window. The outside world looked normal. And yet, something felt... *off*.

She pulled the window shut, but before she could turn away, a strange thought entered her mind.

If it was just a dream... why do I still feel like something is watching me?

She closed the window with a quiet click.

A strange unease lingered in her chest.

She rubbed her arms, trying to shake it off. *It was just a dream. That's all.*

But then—

Her eyes drifted outside.

Beyond the street, just past the small iron fence that lined the park, a figure sat on the wooden bench. A young man, maybe in his early twenties, dressed in dark clothes. His posture was relaxed, one arm resting on the back of the bench.

But it wasn't his posture that made her stomach twist.

It was the way he was facing directly toward her window.

Her fingers curled against the windowsill. She knew how reflections worked. With the afternoon light hitting the glass, there was no way he could see inside. And yet...A creeping sensation ran down her spine.

She turned away quickly, stepping back from the window. She felt ridiculous. He wasn't watching her. He probably didn't even realize her window was there.

But still—Her heartbeat drummed in her ears. *Why did it feel like he was?*

Probably, she was aware of her feminine nature—that instinctive caution drilled into her by her parents, by society. *Be safe. Be careful. Don't trust strange men.*

But still...Somewhere inside her, there was another feeling. Something less logical. Something she would never say out loud. *She wanted to be stared at.*

Not in a way that made her feel unsafe, but in a way that made her feel... *noticed.*

But only by the right kind of eyes. Not by some random guy sitting in the park. Not by a stranger who probably didn't even realize she existed. And yet, he wasn't ugly.

Dressed in all black, he had this effortless coolness about him. The kind that usually made girls sneak a second glance. But she refused to be one of those girls.

So, she ignored him. Not because she didn't notice, but because *she didn't want to let him know she noticed.*

She turned away, pretending she hadn't seen him at all. Pretending his presence didn't affect her.

But in the back of her mind, she still felt that creeping sensation.

Was he still there? And more importantly—was he really just sitting there, or had he been waiting for something? *Oh God, why am I even thinking about him?*

She let out a small, frustrated sigh and shook her head. *He's just some random guy sitting in the park.* Nothing more. But still... She had never seen him before. At least, that's what she told herself.

Even though—somewhere deep down—she knew that wasn't true.

The truth was, she had seen him *almost every day*. Sitting on that same bench, wearing those same dark clothes, staring out at nothing in particular.

She just... refused to acknowledge him. Refused to *see* him.

Because if she admitted that she noticed him, then she'd have to admit that she had *been noticing him for a long time*.

And that was something she wasn't ready to accept.

She clenched her jaw, forcing her thoughts to stop. Just for a few seconds. Just to prove to herself that she didn't care.

But silence never lasted long.

And when her mind picked up again, it whispered something she didn't like.

What if he's been noticing you too?

Still Hungry

Before she could spiral any deeper into those thoughts, a sudden realization hit her.

She was starving. She hadn't eaten *anything* since morning. She had rushed out to college on an empty stomach, sat through her lectures half-dazed, then come home and collapsed straight onto her desk—without even bothering to change out of her uniform.

Her bag was still lying on the carpet, right where she had carelessly dropped it.

She stretched her arms, feeling the stiffness in her shoulders. *No wonder I feel like crap.*

And then—Footsteps.

Soft but steady, coming up the stairs.

Her mom. Probably coming to check on her. Probably about to nag her for skipping meals again.

She sighed. She already knew the speech she was about to get. *'You don't take care of your health. You're always tired. You need to eat properly, or you'll get sick.'*

And for once, she didn't feel like arguing.

She turned away from the window, finally pulling herself out of her chair, just as the footsteps reached her door—

And then—

They *stopped*.

Silence.

Her hand hovered over the doorknob.

She frowned.

"Mom?"

No answer.

She hesitated for a second before turning the knob.

Then she opened the door. Empty.

The hallway was still. No one was there.

Her stomach dropped. She could have *sworn* she heard footsteps.

For a few seconds, fear gripped her like ice-cold fingers.

Then—Movement.

At the bottom of the stairs.

She exhaled sharply, gripping the doorframe as she spotted her mom standing there, looking up at her.

But something about the way she stood, the way her head tilted slightly—silent, unmoving—made her chest tighten.

Her mom didn't say anything. Didn't call her name like she usually did.

She just... **looked** at her.

But somehow, that look alone was enough. Enough to make her body move on instinct, stepping away from the door. Enough to tell her, without words, *come down and eat*.

She swallowed hard, rubbing her arms as she tried to shake off the lingering unease.

Why does everything feel so weird right now?

Chapter 3: Life always

She glanced at her clock.

Afternoon.

Ugh. No wonder.

Why does sleeping in the afternoon always feel like this?

Like waking up in another world.

She took a deep breath, shaking off the strange feeling clinging to her skin. *It's just in my head.*

Without another thought, she stepped away from the door, grabbing a hair tie from her desk and loosely tying her hair up as she walked down the stairs.

Her mom was already heading back toward the kitchen, her usual self again. The weird silence from earlier was gone, replaced by the familiar sounds of dishes clinking and the faint smell of food.

"You slept too much again," her mom said without looking back. "Come eat something before you faint one day."

She rolled her eyes but said nothing, sliding into her usual chair at the dining table.

The late lunch was simple—nothing special. But the warmth of food in her empty stomach felt grounding, pulling her back to reality.

The eerie feeling from earlier started to fade.

"Did you write well?" Her mom asked.

"Not actually. I am not feeling best". Ally replied.

"You know you have to present your work this Friday!" Her mom said.

"Yeah whatever" Ally said.

For now.

As she ate, a quiet realization settled in her mind.

No matter what's happening in life, no matter how strange or overwhelming things feel...

I should always take care of myself.

Skipping meals, ignoring hunger—it wasn't strength. It wasn't some kind of noble suffering. It was just stupid.

What was the point of worrying about things—about mysterious strangers, about dreams that felt too real, about strange afternoon feelings—if she couldn't even take care of her own body? Something her mom always say, but she would never accept that her mom says right. That's what happens in a family.

She scooped another bite into her mouth, feeling the warmth of the food spread through her.

It was a small thing, but at least right now, she was doing something good for herself.

Maybe that was enough. For now.

As she ate, she glanced up at her mom, who was busy washing dishes. A thought crossed her mind.

"Where is everyone else?" she asked casually.

No response.

She frowned. "Mom?"

Still nothing.

The clinking of dishes and running water drowned out her words.

She sighed, setting her spoon down. "Where is the rest of the family?"

Her mom finally noticed her daughter had said something and turned slightly.

"What?"

She rolled her eyes, now slightly annoyed. "Where *is* everyone?"

"Oh," her mom said, rinsing her hands. "Your twin brothers went to the shop to fetch some chicken. And your father went to pick up your older sister from university."

She blinked.

Ah, yes. Her twin brothers.

Her *chaotic, energy-draining, ear-splitting* twin brothers.

Their very existence always made her head feel like it was going to explode. The constant noise, the endless pranks, the way they *never* seemed to run out of energy.

She *always* wished—just *one* of them—would *disappear* for a while.

Not because of that strange dream she had earlier. But because she had wished for it so many times before... maybe that's *why* she had that dream.

And Why chicken? She asked.

"What honey?" Her mom asked

"Nothing" She replied.

Why would people eat something to get energy that can't even stand on it's feet. The breed chicken, she was thinking about. If a chicken can't stand on it's feet properly then same would pass down to it's eaters. She thought.

Probably that's the reason she is so lazy. She thought giggling.

BANG!

The front door *slammed* open.

Her heart jumped into her throat for a split second—before reality hit her.

The monsters weren't coming.

The real *monsters* had arrived.

"CHOO CHOO! MOVE ASIDE! THE TRAIN IS HERE!"

Her twin brothers burst into the house, their voices echoing through the walls. One had his hands on the other's shoulders as they *stormed* into the kitchen, completely unaware of the *near-heart attack* they had just given their sister.

They skid to a stop, dramatically presenting the pack of chicken to their **Captain Mom** in the kitchen.

"Mission completed, ma'am!" one of them declared.

She sighed, rubbing her temples.

Her peace was over.

She watched with narrowed eyes as the twins bounced around the kitchen, still riding the high of their "mission success."

But then—

"Hey, wanna see a magic trick?" one of them smirked, turning to the other.

The younger twin's eyes lit up. "Oh yeah, let's show her!"

Before she could even refuse, the older twin reached into his pocket and pulled out a tiny pouch.

"Behold!" he announced, holding it up like it was some ancient artifact. "The **Dust of Disappearance!**"

She raised an eyebrow. "Dust of what now?"

The younger twin straightened his posture, pretending to be serious. "This, dear sister, is a mystical substance that can make people... *vanish*."

She stared blankly. "Right."

But before she could say anything else—

POOF!

A sudden *puff* of black dust exploded in the air.

She coughed, waving her hand in front of her face. "Ugh, what the—"

And then she froze.

The younger twin was **gone**.

Her heart skipped a beat.

"What the—?" She looked around. "Where did he go?"

The older twin grinned mischievously. "Ta-daaaa!"

She blinked.

Then scowled.

"Okay. Not funny. Where is he?"

The older twin just wiggled his eyebrows. "Who?"

Her jaw clenched. "*Your twin*. Where. Is. He.*"

The older twin gasped dramatically. "I had a twin brother?! This is shocking news!"

Her eye twitched.

Her mom, still occupied with the dishes, simply sighed. "Whatever nonsense you two are doing, undo it *now* before you break something."

The older twin chuckled, clapped his hands together, and then—

POOF!

The younger twin *reappeared* in the exact same spot he had vanished from, grinning like an idiot.

"Tadaaaa!"

She exhaled, rubbing her temples. "*I hate you both*."

The twins just high-fived. "That means we did it right!"

POOF!

The black dust burst into the air, making her instinctively shut her eyes for a second.

When she opened them—

The younger twin was **gone**.

She blinked.

Her heart skipped a beat.

"Wait... what?"

The older twin stood there with the **biggest** smirk on his face, arms crossed like some kind of magician.

She looked left. Looked right. Checked behind the kitchen counter. **Nothing**.

"Where is he?" she demanded.

The older twin simply shrugged. "Vanished, dear sister."

Her eye twitched.

And then—

THUMP.

A low *dull* sound came from under the table.

Her gaze snapped down just in time to see a figure crawling out, **rubbing his head in pain**.

The younger twin *wobbled* to his feet, wincing. "Ow, ow, ow—stupid table!"

The older twin burst into laughter. "You ruined it, idiot!"

The younger one just scratched his head, still chuckling through the pain. "Hey, I stayed quiet for so long! But my head wasn't supposed to vanish too!"

She rolled her eyes so hard they nearly fell out of her skull.

Her mom sighed from the kitchen sink. "Stop playing stupid tricks before one of you actually disappears for real."

The twins exchanged a glance.

Then grinned.

"Now *that* sounds like a challenge."

She groaned. "I am **so done** with both of you."

Just as she was about to escape the madness, the front door opened.

Her father stepped in, followed by her older sister.

"Assalamu Alaikum," their mom greeted warmly, already moving toward them. "Tea or water?"

"Water is fine," her father replied, stretching his shoulders as if he'd carried the weight of the world today.

But before anything else could happen—

BAM!

The twins **launched themselves** at their older sister.

"BIG SIIIISSSS!" they yelled in unison, clinging onto her like koalas.

She just laughed, hugging them tightly like they were her **favorite people in the world**.

Her younger sister, however?

She just sat there, unimpressed.

Because **why** did they **always** have to act like puppies around the oldest sibling?

Like, **seriously**.

They acted like she was some **angel** while treating their other sister like a **living enemy**.

Maybe because she treated them like **annoying mosquitoes**, but still—

As if reading her thoughts, her older sister turned to her with a knowing smile.

"You should love them a little more," she said softly, ruffling one twin's hair. "Or at least... hate them a little less."

Her younger sister scoffed, grabbing her glass of water. "I'll think about it."

Which meant **never**.

The twins grinned. "That's a win for us!"

She took a sip of water, sighed, and muttered, "I *really* need a new family."

Chapter 4: Professor Oswald

Clack. Clack. Clack.

The sound of an **old typewriter** filled the cozy café. Unlike the digital world, there was something raw, something **undeniably human** about the ink staining paper.

At a corner table, a young **school girl**—barely in her teens—named flipped through the freshly typed pages.

She looked up at the man sitting across from her. “Are you sure this will work?”

Mr. Oswald—if that was even his real name—gave a small, knowing smile. “Most probably.”

She beamed, hugging the pages. “Thank you, Mr. Oswald!” And with that, she dashed out of the café, disappearing into the bustling street.

The man leaned back, adjusting the cuffs of his black coat.

A chuckle came from the seat beside him.

“Really? **Mr. Oswald?**”

The man turned his gaze toward his **companion**—a well-dressed figure, one leg crossed over the other, swirling a cup of untouched coffee.

“How many times are you going to change your name and hide your **true identity?**”

For a second, silence lingered between them.

Then, Oswald smirked, fingers brushing against the **cold silver ring** on his hand.

“As many times as it takes.”

The café where Oswald and Logi sat was far from ordinary. It was an old, dimly lit establishment nestled in a forgotten corner of the city—one of those places that seemed to exist outside of time. The air carried the faint scent of aged wood and spiced coffee, blending with the soft hum of a distant jazz record playing on an antique gramophone.

Heavy red velvet curtains lined the windows, blocking out most of the outside world, leaving only slivers of moonlight to seep through. The chandeliers above flickered faintly, as if unsure whether to stay lit or give in to the encroaching darkness. The walls were adorned with portraits—faces of long-dead strangers who seemed to watch over the patrons with knowing eyes.

Most customers here kept to themselves, whispering in hushed voices or reading tattered books beneath the dim glow of candlelit tables. It was the kind of place where secrets were exchanged more than pleasantries, and where time itself seemed to slow, bending to the will of those who lingered.

Logi leaned back in his chair, arms crossed, smirking at Oswald. “Really? ‘Mr. Oswald’ this time? How many times are you gonna change your name, man?”

Oswald didn't even look up from his typewriter. A slow smile crept onto his face as he pressed another key. "As many times as it takes."

Logi scoffed. "At least pick something less dramatic. You sound like a character from one of your own damn stories."

Oswald finally glanced at him, eyes glinting with amusement. "At least my name isn't as stupid as yours. 'Logi'—seriously? Sounds like a kid's toy. No wonder no one pays attention to you."

Logi rolled his eyes. "Says the guy typing away on a relic from the past like some tortured soul. What are you even writing now? Another one of your twisted little stories?"

Oswald leaned back, stretching his fingers. "Something like that. A story about twins. A girl who dreams of them, and a writer who doesn't know if he's writing the story or if the story is writing him."

Logi raised a brow. "Sounds like you're losing it."

Oswald smirked, tapping the side of his head. "Or maybe I'm just seeing things more clearly than you ever will."

Before Logi could respond, the café door creaked open. Both men turned to look. But no one walked in. Just the sound of footsteps—faint, distant, yet somehow inside the room.

Oswald's fingers hovered over his typewriter. Logi frowned. "Tell me you heard that."

Oswald didn't answer. He was too busy staring at the empty doorway, where a folded piece of paper lay on the ground. He reached for it, hesitated, then picked it up.

One sentence was scrawled across the page in deep black ink:

You're not the only writer in this story.

Logi exhaled sharply. "Another fucking letter this week, eh?"

He leaned forward, voice low. "Who the hell is doing this? Do they know about us? Are they a threat?"

Oswald turned the letter over, studying it. "That's the question, isn't it?" He tapped the page with a finger. "They know enough to keep finding us. That means one of two things. Either they're watching... or they're part of the story, too."

Logi ran a hand through his hair, eyes scanning the café. "Then we need to figure out what they want before they decide to write our ending."



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Oswald didn't answer.

For a long moment, silence settled between them. Both vampires remained still, their senses sharp, bodies poised for whatever threat lurked unseen.

Then—glass shattered.

A brick came hurtling through the café window, cutting through the dim light like a bullet. Oswald moved on instinct, his hand snapping up just in time to catch it before it struck his face. But the real danger wasn't the brick.

Sunlight.

A single ray, thin yet merciless, pierced through the fractured window, spilling onto his skin. A sizzle, the sharp sting of burning flesh—Oswald recoiled, his body moving before the pain could settle. In a blur, he was gone from the path of the light, landing in the café's darker recesses.

Meanwhile, Logi was already at the door. He pushed it open, stepping onto the street, eyes scanning for any sign of the attacker. The alleyways stretched empty before him. No movement. No lingering presence. Whoever had thrown the brick had vanished as quickly as they had come.

But the message was clear.

They weren't welcome here.

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Logi exhaled sharply. "Another fucking letter this week, eh?"

He leaned forward, voice low. "Who the hell is doing this? Do they know about us? Are they a threat?"

Oswald turned the letter over, studying it. "That's the question, isn't it?" He tapped the page with a finger. "They know enough to keep finding us. That means one of two things. Either they're watching... or they're part of the story, too."

Logi ran a hand through his hair, eyes scanning the café. "Then we need to figure out what they want before they decide to write our ending."

So, Logi sees the letter and reacts, saying, **"Another fucking letter this week, eh? Who the hell is sending these? Do they know about us? Are they a threat?"**

Oswald, still calm, casually tears the envelope open and pulls out the letter. His eyes scan the words, and for a split second, his expression changes—just a flicker of something unreadable before he smirks.

"Threat? No, I don't think so. But they definitely know something."

Logi leans closer, narrowing his eyes. **"What does it say?"**

Oswald slides the letter toward him. The handwriting is elegant but eerie, written in dark ink. The words are simple yet chilling:

"You're running out of names to hide behind, aren't you?"

So, Oswald just chuckles, folding the letter neatly before tucking it into his coat pocket. He leans back in his chair, taking a slow sip of his drink. **"Running out of names? How dramatic. As if I don't have a thousand more."**

Logi, clearly more concerned, drums his fingers on the table. **"You should take this seriously. Someone out there knows what you are."**

Oswald raises an eyebrow, still completely unfazed. **"And? It's not like they can do anything about it."**

Logi huffs in frustration. **"Unless they can."**

For a moment, silence lingers between them, only the distant hum of the café filling the air. Then, Oswald glances at the window, where the city lights blur against the glass. His smirk deepens. **"Well, let's see how far they want to play."**

Logi leans forward, his sharp eyes locked onto Oswald. **"You should take this seriously. Someone out there knows what we are."**

Oswald gives him a lazy grin. **"And? Let them know. It's not like they can do anything about it."**

Logi scoffs, crossing his arms. **"Unless they can."**

Oswald raises an eyebrow. **"You sound paranoid, Logi. You forget—we're not the hunted. We're the ones who hunt."**

Logi shakes his head. **"You're too relaxed about this. Someone is watching us closely. Humans don't just play around with words like this unless they know something."**

Oswald taps the letter against the table, thinking for a moment. Then, with a smirk, he tucks it away. **"Then let's play along, shall we?"**

Oswald stretches, letting out a slow breath as he pockets the letter. "Enough of this. We have work to do."

Logi exhales sharply. "Yeah. Night won't last forever."

Without another word, they step out into the alley, where the scent of the city lingers in the cool night air—metal, damp stone, and the faint, distant pulse of human life.

They move like shadows, unseen, unheard, blending into the dark corners of the streets. Their job isn't glamorous—it never is. But it keeps them alive. Vampires don't feast like the myths say; they take only what's needed, just enough to survive. Anything more would be... excessive. Dangerous.

Oswald prefers efficiency. A quick stop at the back of a dimly lit tavern, where drunken patrons stumble into the night, unaware of the figures slipping past them. A moment later, his hunger is sated, his presence barely noticed.

Logi, on the other hand, is slower, more methodical. He chooses carefully, ensuring he doesn't take too much, leaving his targets dazed but unharmed. Even now, his thoughts are with those under the bridge—the beggars, the lost souls who rely on him.

By the time the first hints of dawn threaten the horizon, they part ways.

Oswald heads home, walking through the grand gates of a house that isn't truly his. It belongs to his father's grand-grandsons now. They don't know what he is; they only know him as an eccentric relative, always around but never aging. He has watched generations come and go, watched the bloodline of the man who once saved him continue on. A legacy he does not belong to, but one he chooses to stay near.

Logi, meanwhile, returns to the bridge, where the world forgets those who live beneath it. The beggars stir as he approaches, some murmuring in their sleep, others barely acknowledging his return. He sets down a bag—food he won't eat, warmth he doesn't need.

"Eat," he says simply, his voice low but firm.

A few tired hands reach for the offering. Logi leans back against the cold stone, arms crossed. Hunger still gnaws at him, but it doesn't matter. They need it more.

As the first light of morning creeps across the city, both vampires retreat into the safety of the shadows.

For now, they are alive. And that is enough.

Logi sits under the bridge, arms resting on his knees as he watches his beggar friends pick at the food he brought. Their hands shake, their eyes dull.

It's getting worse.

The streets have become harsher, and the scraps he manages to scavenge aren't enough. Some of them cough—deep, rattling sounds that speak of sickness. Others barely move at all, too weak to do anything but wait.

And his mother—

He clenches his jaw.

The old woman who had taken him in when he was just a lost, aimless teenager—she was fading. Every time he returned to her, she looked smaller, her breath more fragile. He brought her bites of food, tried to keep her warm, but it wasn't enough. It never was.

A curse.

That's what this was. This existence.

Being a vampire meant he didn't starve. He didn't fall sick. He didn't crumble away like the rest of them. But what was the point of it if he had to watch everyone else suffer? If he could only bring them scraps while they wasted away in front of him?

He had seen too many of them die. Friends who had laughed with him, fought with him, shared what little they had with him. Now, they were gone. Not because of war, not because of violence—but because of hunger. A slow, pitiful death that he could do nothing to stop.

And his mother would be next.

His fingers dig into his arms. He doesn't want to think about it.

But the truth sits heavy in his chest.

The sun is rising.

The world will move on.

And he will still be here, watching it all happen.

The dim light of dawn creeps under the bridge, stretching long shadows over the cold ground. Logi sits beside his mother, watching her frail fingers tremble as she reaches for his hand.

"Logi," she whispers, voice thin like worn fabric. "Don't you have anyone you can ask for help?"

His jaw tightens.

She's looking at him with those tired eyes, the same way she always did when she worried too much. He hates it.

Because he knows the answer.

He does have someone. A friend. Someone who would help if he only asked.

Oswald.

But the thought alone makes something twist deep in his gut.

"No," he says simply.

Her fingers squeeze his, weak but firm. "I don't believe that."

He swallows, staring at the cracks in the ground. The ghosts of old memories stir in his mind—memories of when he once dared to ask for help.

A long time ago, back when he still ran with his pack. Back when he still thought bonds meant something.

He had been desperate then. His mother had fallen ill. The beggars he protected were starving. He had swallowed his pride, forced himself to be vulnerable, and asked for help.

And they had laughed.

They had looked at him—not with sympathy, not with understanding—but with something far worse. Disgust. Pity.

"Logi, begging for help? What, you getting soft on us?"

"Thought you were stronger than that."

Weak. That's what they saw him as. That's what they whispered when he walked away, their backs already turned, their eyes already elsewhere.

And that night, as he sat under the bridge, staring at the empty sky, he made a promise to himself.

Never again.

Never again would he put himself in that position. Never again would he let anyone see him that way. If asking for help meant being seen as weak, then he would carry everything on his own.

No matter how heavy it got.

His mother exhales, her grip loosening. He finally dares to look at her.

She knows.

Maybe she doesn't know the details, but she knows the weight on his shoulders, the wounds he doesn't show.

"You don't have to do this alone," she murmurs. "You never did."

He doesn't answer.

Because if he does, his voice might break.

And he won't let that happen.

Not again.

The wooden floor creaks under Oswald's boots as he steps inside, shutting the door softly behind him. The scent of stale air and dust greets him—his home for over a century, yet it never truly felt like one.

With a tired sigh, he heads straight for the kitchen. His fingers curl around the cold glass bottle of tomato ketchup sitting on the fridge shelf. He gives it a lazy shake, watching the thick red liquid move sluggishly inside.

"Breakfast," he mutters to himself.

It would last him the whole day.

His feet move toward the stairs, the floorboards groaning beneath his weight. Just as he reaches the second floor, a door swings open.

His sister-in-law steps out, wrapped in a robe, her hair slightly messy from sleep. Upon seeing him, her lips curl in disgust.

"You back, creep?" she sneers. "I wish you'd burn in the first ray of sun this morning."

Oswald halts mid-step, expression unreadable. He's heard it all before.

"But of course," she scoffs, "that'll never happen, will it? A curse like you lasts longer than it should."

She brushes past him, heading downstairs, but not before muttering under her breath, "Disgusting."

Oswald exhales slowly.

He doesn't move. Doesn't react.

He just stands there, fingers tightening around the ketchup bottle.

Then, suddenly—

"Are you even listening?!" she snaps, voice rising in irritation. "God, I hate sharing a roof with you! I can't even breathe properly with a monster lurking around!"

A door bursts open.

Her husband—an aging man with gray-streaked hair—steps out, his face twisted in annoyance.

"The hell's going on here?" he growls, eyes landing immediately on Oswald.

Before Oswald can even blink—

SLAP!

A sharp sting spreads across his cheek. His head barely tilts from the impact, but the sound echoes in the narrow hallway.

"Are you bothering her again?" the old man barks. His voice is thick with accusation, as if the crime had already been committed, as if the truth had never mattered.

Oswald's fingers twitch, but he doesn't move.

His sister-in-law clutches her robe dramatically. "I just want some peace, but I can't even have that in my own house!"

The old man glares at Oswald like he's filth beneath his shoe. "You touch her, you so much as look at her the wrong way, and I swear, I'll—"

Oswald finally speaks.

Calm. Quiet. Unshaken.

"I never have. I never will."

The old man scowls. "Like hell I believe that."

Oswald simply turns away, walking past them without another word.

It's always like this.

No matter what he does, no matter how much space he gives them, they will always see him as something vile.

Something that doesn't belong.

The sting on his cheek fades quickly—his body barely registers such things anymore. But the weight in his chest? That lingers.

By the time he locks himself in his room, the first light of dawn is beginning to creep through the curtains, stretching across the floor and up to his face. He places the ketchup bottle on the desk, letting out a long breath.

Another day. Another cycle. It doesn't burn. It used to.

But just like everything else, the pain has become something he simply doesn't care about anymore.

Oswald tilts his head slightly, letting the warm glow touch his skin. A reminder of what he once was. A reminder of what he can never be again.

Then, a small, knowing smirk tugs at the corner of his lips.

How *pathetic* they are. His so-called family—spitting words like poison, acting like they hold some power over him. But they don't know the truth.

They don't know *him*.

If they did, they wouldn't waste their breath on curses and slaps.

A vampire isn't born every day.

And he wasn't just thinking that.

He *was* special.

He shuts his eyes, the smirk lingering.

They'd see it someday.

One way or another.

He collapses onto the bed, staring at the ceiling, waiting for sleep to come.

Not that it ever does.

He shuts his eyes, the smirk lingering.

They'd see it someday.

One way or another.

But as he leans against the door, a different memory creeps in. One he hasn't entertained in a long time.

Once, he used to care. *Too much*.

Back in his old pack, Oswald was always the first to step forward, the first to offer a hand. No one even had to ask—he was just *there*, ready to do whatever needed to be done.

But it had never been enough.

No matter what he did, no matter how much he gave, all he got in return were resentful glares and whispered blame. Every mistake, every misfortune—they found a way to make it *his* fault.

And eventually, he understood.

It wasn't about what he did or didn't do. They simply wanted someone to bear the weight of their hatred.

So he stopped.

Stopped giving. Stopped offering. Stopped *caring*.

Even now, when he knows exactly what kind of life Logi is living, he doesn't step in. He doesn't bring food. He doesn't offer a place to rest. He doesn't ease the weight of his friend's struggles.

Not because he doesn't want to.

But because he's waiting.

Waiting for Logi to *ask*.

Because if there's one thing Oswald learned, it's that offering kindness uninvited only turns you into a target.

And he refuses to be anyone's target ever again.

At the same time, in two very different places, both Oswald and Logi lay still.

Oswald, stretched out on his bed, staring at the wooden ceiling above. The room was dark, the only light being the faint glow of the morning sun slipping through the cracks of his heavy curtains. The air smelled of dust, old books, and the lingering scent of the cold night air he carried in with him. His limbs felt heavy, but sleep wouldn't come.

Logi, curled up in a pile of old clothes beneath the bridge, listened to the distant sounds of the city waking up. The ground beneath him was stiff, pressing into his back like it always did. A chill seeped through the fabric he used as a blanket, but he was used to it. His stomach ached faintly—not from hunger, but from the weight of everything else.

Both their minds drifted to the same place.

Old faces. Old voices. Old ghosts.

Friends they used to have.

Some were gone in an instant, their bodies turning to dust in the sun, lost to a single mistake.

Some faded slowly, cursed beyond saving, their own existence betraying them.

And others... were taken. Hunted by humans who didn't see them as anything but monsters.

Oswald exhaled, rubbing a hand over his face. *How many are even left?*

Logi let out a quiet breath, pressing a hand over his eyes. *How many more will be lost?*

And the worst part was—

Neither of them could do anything about it.

Not anymore.

Then he, Oswald closed his eyes for while to give them some rest. But just couldn't, cause he suddenly remember that letter they found in the café. He quickly reached his pocket with his left hand and pulled out the letter. Oswald stared at the letter in his hands, running his fingers over the ink-stained words. He opened it again in hope of finding anything else then those words which still scares him for a some reason. The message remained the same—sharp, taunting, as if whoever had sent it already knew what path he would take. But he didn't find anything, still. He kept looking at it for half an hour. Then he started checking for those small clues he had been hoping for. But now, as his gaze trailed lower, something caught his eye. A mark. Small, almost hidden at the bottom of the page. A diamond-shaped emblem, intricate yet oddly familiar.

This time his eyes caught something. A symbol, a mark, a representation of a cult. At first glance he couldn't even recognize the symbol, but then it seems him like a diamond

His breath hitched. His fingers froze.

He knew this shape.

Slowly, almost on instinct, he reached for the buttons of his shirt. One by one, they came undone until he pulled the fabric apart, exposing his stomach to the pale morning light seeping through the curtains.

There it was. The same mark. The same shape. The same intricate design, etched onto his skin like it had always belonged there.

Chapter 5: The quest

The Cult That Wrote Me

His mind raced. How? Why? He had never paid attention to this before. It had been there for as long as he could remember, just another part of him—insignificant, meaningless. But now?

Now, someone else knew about it.

Oswald clenched the letter in his fist, his jaw tightening.

This wasn't just some warning. This was a call. A reminder. And whoever had sent it... they knew exactly who he was.

For the first time in a long while, Oswald felt something he had buried deep—something that clawed at him from the past. A ghost of a memory, just out of reach.

He needed answers.

And for that... he needed Logi.



The chamber of Sire Intendy was vast, its walls swallowed by shadows so deep they seemed to pulse with something *alive*. The air was heavy, thick with unseen weight, as if the room itself was aware of the two intruders standing before the throne of obsidian.

"Bring them to me" Deja read through the book

"Yes Sir" Deja replied.

Oswald and Logi stood still, their gazes locked onto the figure before them—Sire Intendy, unmoving, unreadable. The silence stretched, stretching thin like a blade pressed against skin.

Oswald finally spoke. His voice was calm, but his fingers twitched at his sides. "We came for answers."

Sire Intendy did not respond. He did not need to. The very space around him whispered—words unspoken, a presence that did not require language to be understood.

Logi inhaled sharply, his usual composure shaken by the weight of something unseen. "And we're not leaving without them," he added, though his own voice carried a note of hesitation.

A moment passed. Then another.

And then—

A voice.

Smooth. Unhurried. Amused.

"Well, well... took you long enough."

Oswald turned first, his body shifting instinctively into a defensive stance. Logi followed, eyes narrowing at the figure now leaning against the far wall.

Tall. Athletic. Draped entirely in black. His shoulders were broad, his posture effortless, one foot crossed over the other as if he had been watching the entire exchange with nothing more than mild curiosity.

The flickering torchlight barely illuminated his features, but his smirk was unmistakable.

"You two look lost," the vampire continued, his voice laced with something just shy of mockery. He pushed off the wall, stepping forward slowly. "Sire Intendy doesn't entertain guests often. You must be *special*."

Logi: "Oh what the heck.....look, Oswald. A vampie. A vampie.

Oswald remained silent in confusion. He was just, couldn't believe there was anyother left. Or he was just too happily shocked to even say something.

Hi, I am frost. It's blood to meet you. Frost brought his hand towards Oswald. Oswald didn't move his hand yet. A weird silence took over their handshake.

She Thought

Oh my he is so cool. **Irah** said excitedly while lying on his stomach on the bed in his room. I would like to shake hand with him. No wait, I wouldn't make first move. Or I would keep him waiting. No wait I would ignore him. Or I can show him I am not interested. Oooh. I am so sonfused. I don't even know what I want myself.

She laughed: He doesn't even exist and yet I am thinking about him so much. Sometimes I can't even listen myself. Hahaha. It's most of the time.

Irah turned her side to his back and brought the book up in the air in front of his face.

She wished: I wish I was a vampire too. So that I could better understands how vampires actually thinks. But it doesn't matter. He just wouldn't be able to ignore me. I am the best. Like best of the best. I am perfect.

Hey stupid! Come here. Take your uncle's bag to the door. Hurry up. Peggy shouted. ARGHHHHH! Irah growled. Here we go again. Not a single day in peace. Why can't I even think romantic peacefully. Hurry up, Peggy shouted again.

Coming, Irah replied.

She threw the book on the bed and jumped off of it in anger and frustration. Irah opened the door and through the hall way to his uncles room. She picked a black leathared bag with double long strips to grab. She grabbed the one string and started pulling the bag which was still touching the ground. She was angry but suddenly, she took the bag off the ground and picked it in his lap. She realized it's not uncle's mistake. She reached the front door. The door has twho small transparent glasses. She looked through it outside. Cyclist were passing . The same time everyday. She always wanted to ride the bicycle.

Hey stupid, Miss **peggy** said again.

She got scared and suddenly turned back. Oh, that same old goat, Irah said in his mind

Miss peggy, a 50 years old bitter women. She hates her nephew. She don't want her in this house. Not even his brother.

What did I told you to do? Peggy said.

I brought it, Irah replied.

Yeah looks like you favored us something, Peggy said again.

But I brought it. I brought the bag to the front door as you asked me to do, Irah replied.

Look who is growing a tongue. Don't forget we feed you. We have been feeding you, Peggy said.

Yeah, for the labour, Irah said.

What did you just say? Peggy asked angrily.

You have the lands. You owe us, Irah replied angrily.

You little.....

Peg! **Uncle barb** said in a rage. You started again? Why don't you leave the kids alone? What's the matter kid? She is taunting you or something?

She asked me to brought the bag and I brought it. But still she is shouting.

Oh Jesus. How many times I told you she is not our maide. I can carry my bag. I can carry my bag to the front door.

But she can carry it too. She is not a kid anymore. She should help us too in his this house. Peggy said.

God help you, Barb said. That's not even a concern, and not even yours. Then he took the bag from Irah's hand and gave a pat on her head. "You can go to your room now." And peg, don't start with her again when I am gone.

Uncle barb reaches for door knob and twist it to open the door and steps out and closes it.

You happy? Peggy said to Irah.

Uncle barb said from outside: I can still hear you!

Irah gave a gentle smile and went to her room. Lizard! Peggy said

Irah going back to her room walking across the hallway, passing from front of a blue wooden door, suddenly remembers that she has a brother. But she never liked the that color. Or she doesn't like that she don't have a blue door for his room too, backed up by the thought her brother is treated less shit ten her. She thought: 'Most probably he brings few pennys in this house. But I do the home tasks here too. Why they don't assumes my work valuable. Girls are hated always. Men are liked. With this belief she opened the door with an expected idea of (evil version of) his brother standing in front of her smiling and giggling. Yukkh she felt.

Light was out, with curtains out and window opened. Fresh and cold air was coming in breaks.

Juan was sitting in a meditating position, with his shirt off, facing outside of the window. His back was looking a bit wider then the last time,
She thought, How did he build his back in just one day. Can we even build our body like this? Like can we grow our muscles at all?
Irah, a small chubby but still slim girl with mostly fat and no muscles at all was thinking this. I know, he is young and have energy. He eats all our food. That's why he looks fit. But how he digest all that food so easily. Oh! I know why. He is a male. And males have fast stomach.

Hey Idiot! Pounding over life again? Who died this time?

Juan didn't reply, or perhaps he didn't even listen her. Not because he hates her, but he have listened that a hundred times. Most probably he wasn't even thinking about it, but only about nothing.

Juan was always been a good guy. Like, really a nice and kind person. And that's what he likes to take a break from few times. Like being careless a few times a day and acting cold on some matters. And it was one of them. A matter of no need to react or prove himself. Just like his room spoke.

Juan's room was still. Unbothered by time, as if it had learned to ignore the ticking clock that echoed from the hallway. The dim, gray light that managed to crawl through the half-parted curtains painted long shadows across the wooden floor. But something was different today.

There were posters on the wall that hadn't been there before. Vibrant prints of super heroes, abstract masculinity, and a strange one with a mysterious guy Irah couldn't recognize. She paused at the door, eyes narrowing.

When did he put these up? she thought. *He never had these things. Always wasting time on useless stuff..*

Her gaze moved from one poster to another, a sneer forming on her lips.

He doesn't have any responsibilities. Just sits around doing nothing, like he's some monk or philosopher. Why is he like this? Her thoughts sharpened. *Most men are responsible. They sacrifice for their families. They bring in money. They worry. They protect. But him—he just eats, broods, and makes that stupid bitch face all day.*

She took a step closer, arms crossed now.

He probably just thinks about girls all day too. That's all boys do, right? Maybe that's what those posters are about. Fantasies. Escapes. Stupid dreams.

Yet even as she judged him, a small part of her felt something she couldn't place. A mix of envy and confusion—at how someone could live so quietly, so detached, while she felt tangled in invisible ropes every day. Expectations. Chores. Judgments. No room for new posters. No time to be still.

Juan still hadn't turned around.

, no shelves full of trophies or clutter. Just a small mattress near the corner, a stack of three books—one half-open as if abandoned mid-thought—and a worn-out rug with faded tribal patterns lying beneath him.

The air was layered. It held the faint smell of old wood and something earthy—perhaps from the potted aloe vera plant that sat on the window sill, its leaves dusted with chalky whiteness from the breeze outside. A single wind chime hung above the window, chiming rarely, as if it, too, was meditating with Juan.

The walls were painted a light, lifeless gray-blue, like the sky right before it rains. There were a few cracks near the ceiling. Some people would've filled them in, painted over them. Juan hadn't. Maybe he liked knowing the room was real—imperfect but steady, quiet but full.

A single low table beside the mattress held a notebook, a steel cup with dried tea stains, and an incense stick holder, long burned down to ash. It was the kind of room that didn't expect visitors, that didn't ask to be seen.

Irah glanced around, eyes scanning for signs of his so-called life. No music player. No phone. No chaos. Just that quiet, stretched-out silence and the faint echo of his breath.

She stepped in and her foot creaked against the wood. For a moment, she almost felt bad—as if her presence broke some sacred solitude.

"Oh my, he is so cool," Irah said excitedly, lying on her stomach on the bed. "I'd like to shake hands with him. No, wait, I wouldn't make the first move. Or maybe I'd keep him waiting... or ignore him. Or act like I'm not interested. Ooh, I'm so confused. I don't even know what I want myself."

She laughed.

"He doesn't even exist, and yet I'm thinking about him so much. Sometimes I can't even hear myself think. Hahaha. Actually... most of the time."

Irah turned onto her back and raised the book above her face.

"I wish I were a vampire too," she whispered. "So I could understand how vampires actually think. But whatever. He wouldn't be able to ignore me. I'm the best. Like, best of the best. I'm perfect."

"Hey, stupid! Come here! Take your uncle's bag to the door—hurry up!" Peggy shouted from outside.

"ARGHHH!" Irah growled. "Here we go again. Not a single day of peace. Can't even think romantically in peace."

"Hurry up!" Peggy yelled again.

"Coming," Irah muttered.

She tossed the book onto the bed and jumped off, frustrated. Through the hallway and into her uncle's room, she spotted the black leather bag with two long straps. She grabbed one and dragged it along the floor. Her anger softened a little. Then, almost without realizing it, she picked the bag up in her lap. Maybe it wasn't Uncle Barb's fault, after all.

She reached the front door. The glass panels—two small, rectangular windows—let her see the street. Cyclists passed by, right on time. Same time every day. She always wanted to ride a bicycle too.

"Hey, stupid," Peggy called again, startling her.

Irah turned around sharply. *That same old goat*, she thought.

Miss Peggy, a bitter woman in her fifties, hated her niece. Truth be told, she didn't want Irah—or her brother—in the house at all.

"What did I tell you to do?" Peggy snapped.

"I brought it," Irah replied.

"Yeah, like you did us some grand favor," Peggy scoffed.

"But I brought the bag to the front door, just like you asked."

"Look who's growing a tongue. Don't forget who's feeding you. We've been feeding you."

"Yeah, for the labor," Irah shot back.

"What did you just say?" Peggy asked angrily.

"You've got land. You owe us," Irah snapped.

"You little—"

"Peg!" Uncle Barb's voice boomed. "You started again? Why don't you leave the kid alone? What's the matter, kid? She taunting you again?"

"She asked me to bring the bag. I brought it. But she's still shouting."

"Oh, Jesus. How many times do I have to say this? She's not our maid. I can carry my own bag."

"But she can carry it too. She's not a kid anymore. She should help around the house," Peggy said coldly.

"God help you," Barb sighed. "That's not even your concern."

He took the bag from Irah and gently patted her head. "You can go to your room now. And Peg—don't start with her again when I'm gone."

Uncle Barb turned the doorknob, stepped out, and closed the door behind him.

"You happy?" Peggy muttered.

"I can still hear you!" Barb shouted from outside.

Irah gave a soft, victorious smile and walked back to her room.

"Lizard," Peggy hissed.

Irah walked through the hallway, passing a blue wooden door. She never liked that color. Maybe she resented that her room didn't have a blue door too. Or maybe it was just that her brother, Juan, always seemed to get better treatment.

He probably brings in a few pennies somehow, she thought. But I do all the housework. Why doesn't anyone value that? Girls are always hated. Men are liked.

She opened the door, half-expecting her brother's smirking face to be there—an evil version of him, laughing like a cartoon villain.

But the room was dim. The curtains were drawn, the window open. Fresh, cold air flowed in, in quiet, uneven bursts. Juan sat cross-legged on the floor, shirtless, meditating, facing the window. His back looked broader than before.

How did he build his back in just one day? Can someone grow muscles that fast? she wondered. He's young, he eats everything. That's why he's fit. But how does he digest it all so easily? Oh, right. He's a guy. Guys have faster stomachs.

"Hey, idiot! Pounding over life again? Who died this time?"

Juan didn't reply. Maybe he hadn't heard. Maybe he'd heard it too many times. Or maybe, just maybe, he wasn't thinking at all.

Juan had always been a good guy. Too good. The kind of person who needed a break from kindness once in a while. Today seemed like one of those breaks. A moment to be careless. Cold.

His room was still. Time didn't move here. The hallway clock ticked, but this space ignored it. Long shadows painted the floor, shaped by the pale light sneaking past the curtains. But something was off.

Posters hung on the walls—new ones. Superheroes. Abstract masculinity. And one of a mysterious man Irah didn't recognize. She squinted.

When did he put these up? He never liked this stuff. Always wasting time.

Her gaze moved slowly from poster to poster, irritation simmering.

He doesn't have any responsibilities. Just sits around like he's some monk or philosopher. Most men are responsible. They work. They provide. They protect. But him? He eats, broods, and makes that stupid moody face all day.

She stepped inside, arms crossed.

He probably just thinks about girls too. That's what boys do, right? Posters, fantasies, stupid dreams.

Yet even in her judgment, something else crept in—a strange mix of envy and curiosity. How could someone live so quietly while she felt tangled in invisible chains? Expectations. Chores. Judgment. No room for posters. No time for silence.

Juan's room had no clutter. Just a mattress in the corner, a small stack of books, a worn tribal rug. The air smelled of old wood and aloe vera—the plant on the window sill dusted by the breeze. A single wind chime above the window gave a rare, soft chime, as if meditating with him.

The walls were a dull gray-blue, cracked near the ceiling. Imperfect. Honest. Juan had never painted over the cracks.

A low table sat beside the mattress. A notebook. A steel cup with tea stains. An incense stick burned down to ash.

It was the kind of room that didn't expect visitors.

Irah stepped in. The floor creaked under her foot. She felt it then—like she had disturbed something sacred. And for a moment, she felt sorry. As if she didn't belong in this silence at all.

The rise of fall.

Suddenly, a lone, thunderous bell tolled — slow and ominous, breaking the silence. It's not good to keep own ones waiting.

Then frost move his hand in front of logi. He quickly shaked. It's great to meet you. I am logi. Logi didn't shake his hand just because he was pleased to meet him. Well, he was somehow relaxed that atleast they have another one of their type. However, the thing He was more hopeful cause He felt like Frost can be a great help. So we should have to have a somekind of connection with Him.

XC

Pleased to meet you too Mr logi (Frost said) by looking at Oswald's eyes.

His gaze flicked between them, measuring, weighing.

Oswald's fingers twitched again. Logi didn't move, but the shift in his stance was subtle—ready.

The stranger's smirk widened. "Relax. If I wanted you dead, you wouldn't have made it pass the door."

The air in the room grew heavier.

Sire Intendy remained silent. Watching.

Oswald and Logi, for the first time since stepping into this room, were no longer sure if they were the hunters—or the hunted.

But how could she not belong there. It's her brother's room and anyone can enter.